CLUB club

2026-11-13

2026-11-13 class

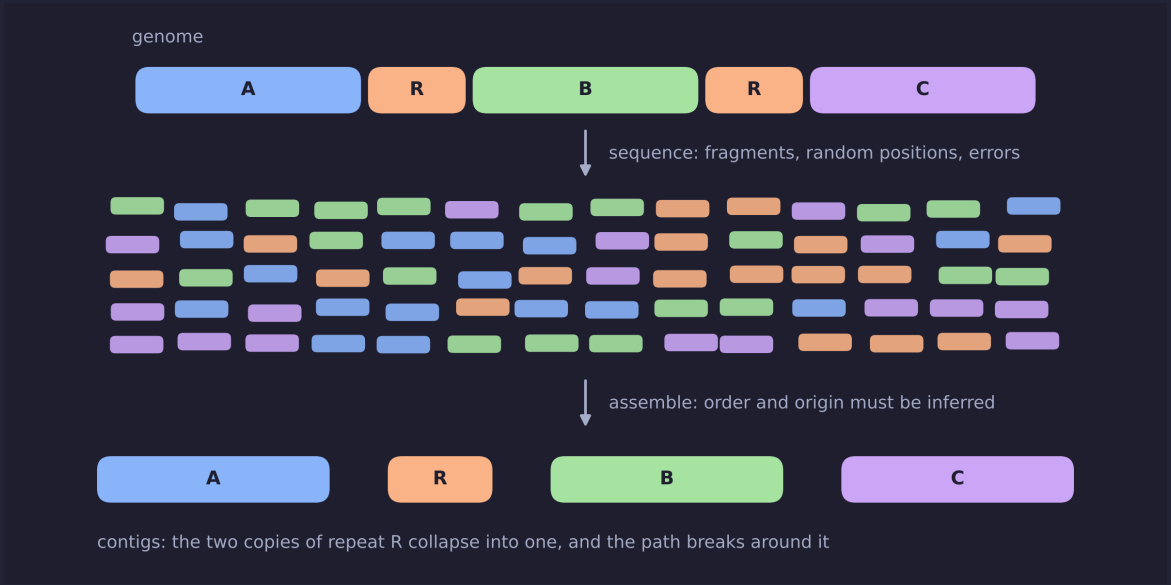
Today we'll cover de novo assembly.

As usual, this is a complicated subject with many packages available.

As usual, in preparing slides for the "class" I realized how little I know.

Why do we need to assemble?

We first break DNA molecules into pieces because the physical sequencing methods have historically only worked on DNA fragments with a small number of nucleotides (up to a few hundred). This is slowly changing, with long-read sequencing. So we try to figure out a genome sequence from its fragments, without a reference sequence.



Note that there is also reference-guided assembly (which we won't discuss today).

When/why would you use de novo assembly?

It is quite contentious whether to use de novo assembly at all.

At a metagenomics conference in Cambridge (about 12 years ago), a strongly expressed opinion was that you should avoid de novo assembly because it takes too long and is too error prone.

But if you have no reference to begin with, perhaps because your sample has something unknown or very distant from known viruses, you don't have much choice (at the nucleotide level).

What makes de novo assembly hard?

It's like doing a fiendishly difficult jigsaw

- The jigsaw puzzle box contains tens of millions of pieces.
- The pieces are from multiple pictures, none of which you get to see.
- Many of the pictures are almost identical.
- The picture you're aiming to reconstruct might be vanishingly small.
- And it might be unlike anything you've ever seen before.
- Many puzzle pieces are missing, duplicated, and damaged.
- Puzzle pieces can fit perfectly in multiple places in a single picture and fit perfectly in multiple pictures.

How Claude describes the difficulties

- Repeat: sections of genomes that are longer than the read length.
- Errors: in reads may result in assembled sequences that are incorrect.
- Coverage: is uneven, so depth is a noisy signal (for copy number).
- Diversity: (multiple infections, strains, quasispecies).
- Scale: is quadratic if an algorithm compares every read with every other.
- Host background: most reads in a clinical sample are not viral.

Three classical approaches to de novo

I asked Claude: "What are the main approaches to de novo assembly?" It gave three categories (and listed 23 example packages!)

Greedy extension

Repeatedly merge the reads or contigs with the best overlap (phrap, CAP3, TIGR, SSAKE, and VCAKE). It makes locally optimal choices with no global view, so repeats cause misjoins. This is largely historical, but survives in some seed-and-extend tools.

Overlap–layout–consensus

Compute all pairwise read overlaps, build a graph with reads as nodes and overlaps as edges, find a layout through it, then call a consensus (Celera Assembler, Newbler, Arachne, Canu). The string graph refinement is used by SGA, miniasm, FALCON, and hifiasm.

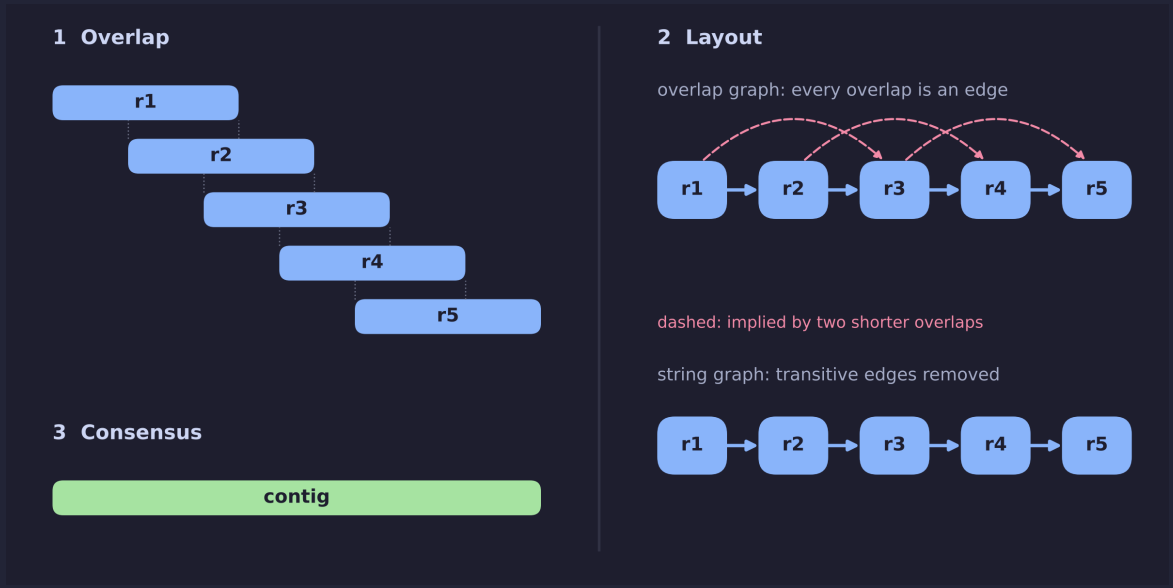
De Bruijn graphs

But first: what is a "graph"?

Break reads into k-mers, with (k−1)-mers as nodes and k-mers as edges, so overlaps are implicit in shared k-mers and never computed (Velvet, ABySS, SOAPdenovo, SPAdes, MEGAHIT). Graph size scales with genome size, not read count. The price is sensitivity to errors, since each error creates up to k spurious k-mers, and repeats longer than k tangle the graph.

Hybrids apply de Bruijn-like ideas to noisy or long reads: Flye, wtdbg2, LJA, rust-mdbg, Verkko.

Overlap-layout-consensus



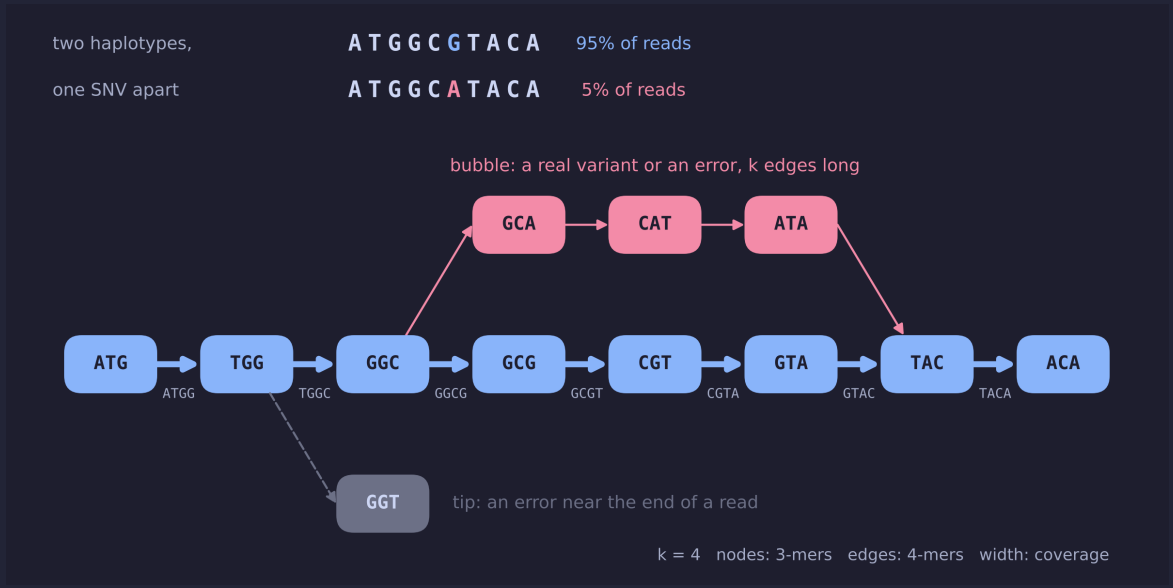
- Overlap all reads via pairwise comparison. Done naively, this is $O(n^2)$ comparisons.
- The overlaps define a graph.
- Walk unambiguous sections of the graph and call a consensus.

String graphs

A refinement of the overlap graph (Myers, 2005).

- Drop reads contained in other reads.
- Remove transitive edges: if r1 overlaps r2 & r2 overlaps r3, remove the r1 to r3 edge.
- What remains: unique stretches become simple paths, repeats become shared paths.

De Bruijn graphs

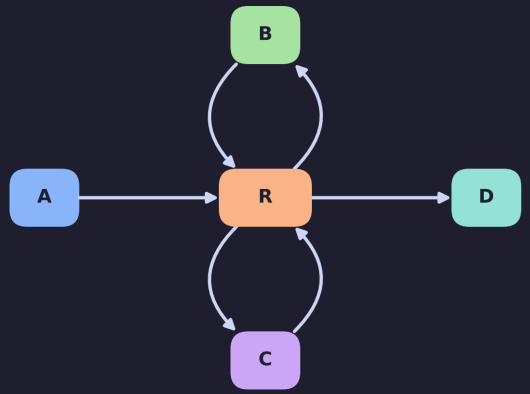


- Nodes are (k-1)-mers, edges are k-mers; overlaps are never computed
- A single difference creates k new edges: a bubble mid-read, a tip near an end

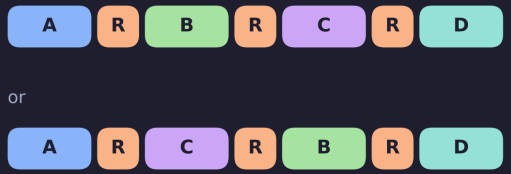
Repeated regions can be a show-stopper

The graph

three copies of R collapse into one node



Two paths use every edge once



Resolving it



a read (or pair) longer than the repeat picks the path

Summary of the three approaches

	Greedy	Overlap-layout-consensus	De Bruijn graph
Unit	read	read	k-mer
Overlaps	best first	all pairs, explicit	implicit in shared k-mers
Graph grows with	n/a	reads x coverage	genome size (plus error k-mers)
Suits	small, simple genomes	fewer, longer reads	many short, accurate reads
Weakness	misjoins at repeats	overlap computation	errors, repeats longer than k
Examples	phrap, CAP3, SSAKE	Celera, Newbler, Canu	Velvet, ABySS, SPAdes, MEGAHIT

It often feels like everyone uses SPAdes!

https://ablab.github.io/spades/

Installing SPAdes

You can't do this via Pixi. You need to either download a pre-built binary or download the source code and build it yourself. The former is much easier (and, some would argue, also riskier).

Their GitHub page https://github.com/ablab/spades has a pointer to the Download page
https://github.com/ablab/spades/releases/latest/

On Linux:

```
$ wget https://github.com/ablab/spades/releases/download/v4.3.0/SPAdes-4.3.0-Linux.tar.gz
$ tar -xzf SPAdes-4.3.0-Linux.tar.gz
$ cd SPAdes-4.3.0-Linux.tar.gz/bin
```

Note: this installation page https://ablab.github.io/spades/installation.html is outdated! It tells you to download version 3.15.

Running SPAdes

First: get a compute node!

On two paired-end FASTQ files, assuming you have changed directory to `SPAdes-3.15.5-Linux/bin` as above:

```
$ spades.py \
    -1 ~/data/fastq/HBV_RISE718_R1_trimmed.fastq.gz \
    -2 data/fastq/HBV_RISE718_R2_trimmed.fastq.gz \
    -o output-dir
```

Options

See https://ablab.github.io/spades/running.html for details.

SPAdes has very few options for parameterizing how it does its thing. But there are various ways of calling it that will adjust its behaviour.

- `--rna` RNA-Seq data sets
- `--rnaviral` viral RNA-Seq data sets
- `--corona` dedicated coronaviral assembly

Also of interest:

- `--continue` - resume an earlier run (perhaps with more RAM)
- `--threads` - should be obvious!
- `--memory N` - specify how much memory (`N` Gb) SPAdes can use

And there are many ways to specify your collection of input files.

On SLURM

There is a way to parallelize some SPAdes steps on a SLURM cluster. But you'll have to compile SPAdes yourself. See this page https://ablab.github.io/spades/hpc.html

SPAdes output

When SPAdes finishes, look in the output directory you specified (`output-dir` in the above). The file you'll likely be most interested in there is `contigs.fasta`. See https://ablab.github.io/spades/output.html for details.

```
drwxr-xr-x 9 jonestc posix-nogroup    688 Nov 13 12:38 .
drwxr-xr-x 4 jonestc posix-nogroup    132 Nov 13 12:40 ..
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup 301869 Nov 13 12:38 assembly_graph_after_simplification.gfa
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup 631694 Nov 13 12:38 assembly_graph.fastg
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup 347269 Nov 13 12:38 assembly_graph_with_scaffolds.gfa
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup 304609 Nov 13 12:38 before_rr.fasta
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup 301980 Nov 13 12:38 contigs.fasta
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup  81226 Nov 13 12:38 contigs.paths
drwxr-xr-x 3 jonestc posix-nogroup    246 Nov 13 12:36 corrected
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup     60 Nov 13 12:34 dataset.info
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup    226 Nov 13 12:34 input_dataset.yaml
drwxr-xr-x 4 jonestc posix-nogroup     93 Nov 13 12:37 K21
drwxr-xr-x 4 jonestc posix-nogroup     93 Nov 13 12:37 K33
drwxr-xr-x 4 jonestc posix-nogroup    405 Nov 13 12:38 K55
drwxr-xr-x 2 jonestc posix-nogroup     40 Nov 13 12:38 misc
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup   1484 Nov 13 12:34 params.txt
drwxr-xr-x 2 jonestc posix-nogroup    438 Nov 13 12:38 pipeline_state
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup   2388 Nov 13 12:34 run_spades.sh
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup   5318 Nov 13 12:34 run_spades.yaml
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup 302058 Nov 13 12:38 scaffolds.fasta
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup  81090 Nov 13 12:38 scaffolds.paths
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup 123932 Nov 13 12:38 spades.log
drwxr-xr-x 2 jonestc posix-nogroup      0 Nov 13 12:38 tmp
-rw-r--r-- 1 jonestc posix-nogroup    778 Nov 13 12:38 warnings.log
```

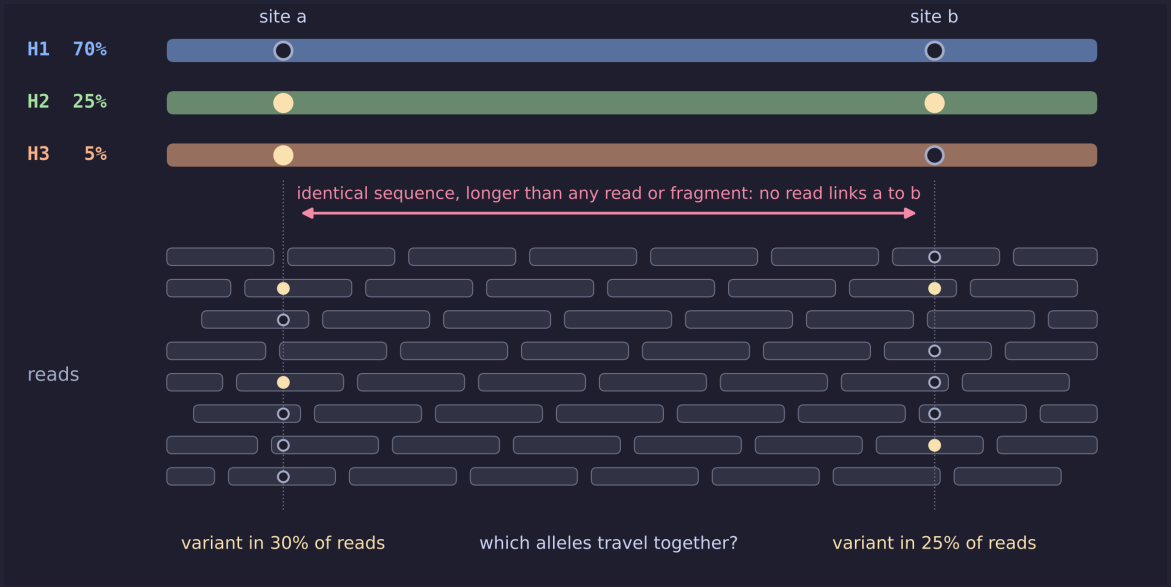
Challenges with viral reads

- Within-host diversity: the sample is a population, so you can't just clean up "noise"
- You are likely to have much more background (host genome, rRNA, mtDNA, lncRNA, bacteria, etc) than virus
- And the virus may have genes acquired from the host!

Virus-specific issues

- Segmented genomes assemble as separate contigs
- Circular genomes (HBV) are cut at an arbitrary point
- Inverted terminal repeats (poxviruses) collapse into one copy

Quasispecies: the phasing problem



- Goal: full-length haplotypes and their frequencies
- Without a linking read, the only signal is frequency, and that fails when frequencies are similar

Why ordinary assemblers fail here

- Variants look like errors. A minority haplotype is a low-coverage bubble, which is exactly what graph cleaning removes.
- The error floor. A variant near the sequencing error rate cannot be called without replicates or unique molecular identifiers (UMIs).
- Identifiability. Sites separated by more conserved sequence than a fragment spans cannot be phased from reads.
- Library artefacts. RT and PCR recombination create chimeric haplotypes; primer bias distorts frequencies.

A review of viral haplotype assembly packages

Have a look at Eliseev et al. (2020) "Evaluation of haplotype callers for next-generation sequencing of viruses." in Infect Genet Evol.

https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7293574/

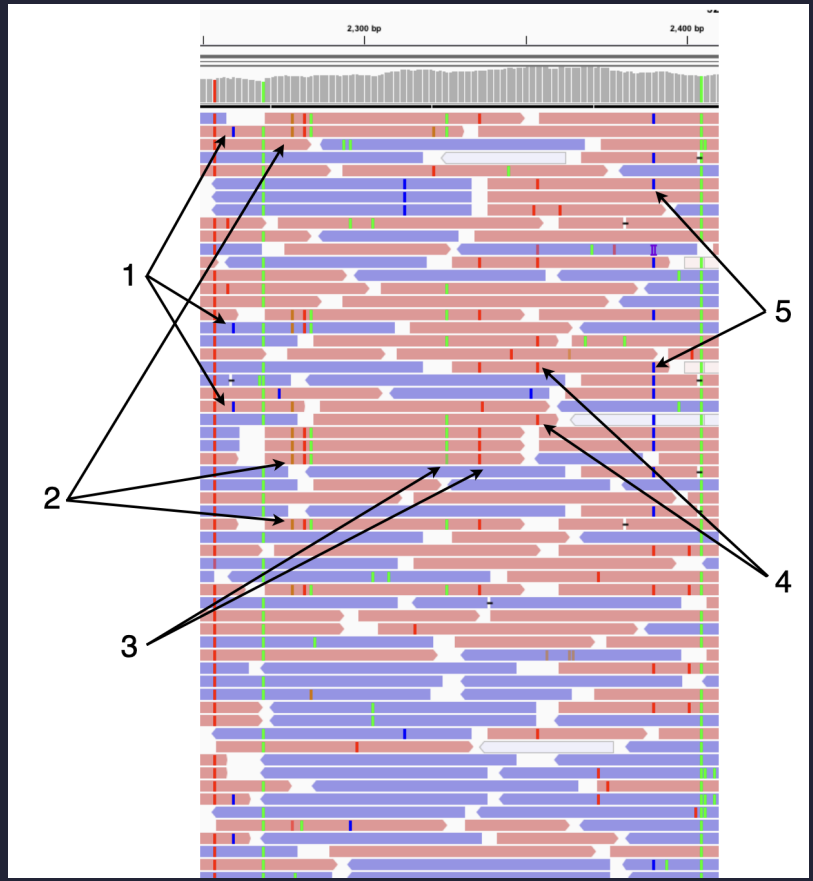
From the Abstract

Currently, the standard practice for assembling next-generation sequencing (NGS) reads of viral genomes is to summarize thousands of individual short reads into a single consensus sequence, thus confounding useful intra-host diversity information for molecular phylodynamic inference. It is hypothesized that a few viral strains may dominate the intra-host genetic diversity with a variety of lower frequency strains comprising the rest of the population. Several software tools currently exist to convert NGS sequence variants into haplotypes. Previous benchmarks of viral haplotype reconstruction programs used simulation scenarios that are useful from a mathematical perspective but do not reflect viral evolution and epidemiology. Here, we tested twelve NGS haplotype reconstruction methods using viral populations simulated under realistic evolutionary dynamics. We simulated coalescent-based populations that spanned known levels of viral genetic diversity, including mutation rates, sample size and effective population size, to test the limits of the haplotype reconstruction methods and to ensure coverage of predicted intra-host viral diversity levels (especially HIV-1).

All twelve investigated haplotype callers showed variable performance and produced drastically different results that were mainly driven by differences in mutation rate and, to a lesser extent, in effective population size. Most methods were able to accurately reconstruct haplotypes when genetic diversity was low. However, under higher levels of diversity (e.g., those seen intra-host HIV-1 infections), haplotype reconstruction quality was highly variable and, on average, poor

Connection to unravelling multiple infections

The problem of assembling haplotype sequences from a viral quasispecies is identical to figuring out the consensus sequences in a multiple infection.



Upcoming (final?) class

- Protein-level matching with DIAMOND.